THE ZEBRA CROSSING

On Feb. 8, hours before finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman tabled a white paper in Parliament on the "governance, economic and fiscal crises" during the UPA regime and steps taken to turn around the economy, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge released a black paper to highlight the failures of the NDA government, terming the past 10 years as an "era of injustice". With plenty cherry-picking in both documents, here's a lowdown on some of the claims:

Compiled by **VIPUL GROVER**





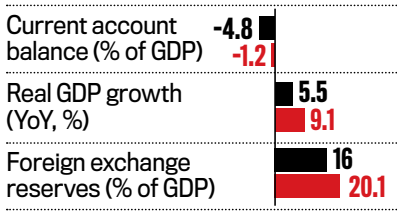
(Left) FM Nirmala Sitharaman; Cong. president Mallikarjun Kharge

ECONOMIC GROWTH

WHITE PAPER

"Since the time our government assumed power in 2014, the Indian economy has undergone many structural reforms that have strengthened the macroeconomic fundamentals. Reforms resulted in the transition of India from the league of the 'Fragile Five' to the league of 'Top Five' in just about a decade...despite unprecedented obstacles of external origin."

Status of India's macroeconomic fundamentals



BLACK PAPER

[It doesn't mention growth figures, focusing on "economic injustices" instead.] "The Modi government's tenure is marked by high rates of unemployment, economic catastrophes, such as demonetisation and flawed GST, which have increased the rich-poor divide and devastated the future of millions of farmers and daily wage workers."

EMPLOYMENT

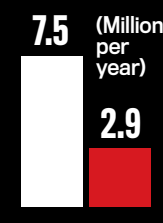
WHITE PAPER

"The UPA government's policy inaction and missteps put off valuable private investment, which could have generated growth and jobs." [The white paper is silent on employment figures and steps taken by the Modi regime to generate jobs.]

BLACK PAPER

"PM Modi has completely failed in his promise to create 20 million jobs every year. Total unemployment was 10 million in 2012 but rose to about 40 million in 2022. A million sanctioned central government posts remain unfilled."

Non-farm jobs created

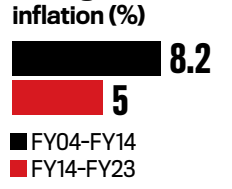


INFLATION

WHITE PAPER

"Inflation raged between 2009 and 2014 and the common man bore the brunt. High fiscal deficits for six years between FY09 and FY14 heaped misery.... From FY10 to FY14, the average annual inflation rate was in double digits."

Average headline inflation (%)



BLACK PAPER

"Prices of daily essentials are touching sky-high levels. Crores of families are suffering, especially women who often manage household budgets."

